

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



People walk on Northwestern University's campus on Monday.
EILEEN T. MESLAR/TRIBUNE

NORTHWESTERN UNIVERSITY

Agreement divides students and faculty

Deal with the Trump administration restores research funding

By Kate Armanini and Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

Northwestern University's \$75 million deal with the White House has brought a mix of relief and concern to campus — concluding months of research cuts, while also marking a significant advance in the president's push to reshape higher education.

The agreement, announced Friday, restores nearly \$800 million in research funding and closes several government probes related to federal anti-discrimination laws.

Some researchers, exhausted by months of cost-cutting in their laboratories, are feeling relieved. But other faculty members and students, along with megadonor Gov. JB Pritzker, raised alarms about the implications of negotiating with the administration of President Donald Trump for academic freedom and institutional independence.

"I still wouldn't have made a deal," said Talia Winiarsky, a 22-year-old American studies major. "But I think the university is in such a tough position, and I do empathize with (administrators)."

The deal is a major milestone in Trump's quest to bring universities to heel. Northwestern is the

Turn to Northwestern, Page 2

OPERATION MIDWAY BLITZ

Most detainees had no record

Nearly 1,900 immigrants were booked during first half of crackdown. Two-thirds had no known criminal convictions or pending charges

By Joe Mahr and Laura Rodríguez Presa
Chicago Tribune

Newly released federal data shows that immigration agents booked in roughly 1,900 immigrants in the first half of Operation Midway Blitz — two-thirds of whom had no known criminal convictions or pending charges.

The latest data offers the

first comprehensive look at the effects of the operation, and a Tribune analysis underscores the divide between the stated goal of the administration of President Donald Trump — to target "the worst of the worst" — with the reality of controversial roundups that typically snagged immigrants living in the the U.S. without permanent legal status even though they had no known

rap sheets.

Of the 1,895 people detained by ICE, 1,271 lacked any criminal record. Another 343 people arrested had a pending criminal charge, while 281 had a criminal conviction. Of those with a criminal conviction, the vast majority of offenses were misdemeanors, traffic citations or nonviolent felonies. Only 28 arrestees —1.5% — had been convicted of a violent

felony or sex crime.

The U.S. Department of Homeland Security, which ran the operation, did not dispute the analysis. In a statement Tuesday, it said that across the country most of those detained had criminal convictions or pending charges as it targets "the worst of the worst criminal illegal aliens — including murderers, rapists, and pedophiles."

It previously has argued that the Trump administration, while

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EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

ICE raid and now eviction

Resident Travaris Ivy leads the media through his apartment building at 7500 S. South Shore Drive in Chicago on Tuesday. The apartment building was the site of a late-night raid in September that was among the most infamous moments in President Donald Trump's Operation Midway Blitz. Now its residents face the possibility of being thrown out of their homes within days. **Chicagoland, Page 4**



Nora Riordan picks up a free hot dog as Bears fans line up on Tuesday at The Wieners Circle in Chicago's Lincoln Park neighborhood after coach Ben Johnson took his shirt off in a postgame celebration for a win over the Eagles. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Fans line up again for free hot dogs

Bears coach rose to Wieners Circle's challenge to take off shirt after win

By Zareen Syed
Chicago Tribune

It happened again. A line of hyper and hungry Bears fans started forming outside The Wieners Circle at 5 a.m. Tuesday, despite the bitter 23-degree temperature. It was all in the name of free hot dogs, courtesy of Chicago Bears head coach Ben Johnson, who rose to the hot dog stand's challenge and took off his

shirt after Friday's win against the Philadelphia Eagles.

At 7 a.m., S. Rosen's, the long-time bakery on Polk Street, delivered 2,000 hot dog buns. Hours later, at 11 a.m., the doors finally opened and The Wieners Circle staff started handing out free hot dogs and their signature slights.

Only in Chicago does an NFL coach taking off his shirt impact so many lives, laughed Emma Kreis, operations manager at

The Wieners Circle.

"But this is what we do and we love it," Kreis said. "Seeing this all come together again has been so wholesome."

The event transpired the same as it had in September, when The Wieners Circle's social media post on 'X' resulted in free hot dogs after Bears' quarterback Caleb Williams threw four

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Illinois settles suit against Monsanto for \$120 million

State alleged company concealed dangers of now-banned PCBs

By Christiana Freitag
Chicago Tribune

Illinois reached a settlement Monday of at least \$120 million with Monsanto Co., the largest producer of now-banned PCBs, to address longstanding contamination across the state.

Illinois Attorney General Kwame Raoul sued Monsanto in 2022 over its denial of the health and environmental harms of the hazardous synthetic chemical, known as polychlorinated biphenyls. The lawsuit alleged Monsanto knowingly concealed the dangers

of PCBs and continued to produce and distribute it for decades.

Under the agreement, the state will receive \$80 million by March 31, which will be disbursed to Chicago and nine surrounding cities of Evanston, Lake Forest, North Chicago, Zion, Beach Park, Glencoe, Lake Bluff, Winnetka and Winthrop Harbor.

Illinois joins Washington, Ohio, Oregon and Virginia in winning damages from Monsanto to fund massive statewide PCB cleanups.

"I'm pleased that this settlement will hold Monsanto accountable for producing and disposing of a dangerous toxic chemical that continues to impact Illinois' natural resources," Raoul said in a state-

Turn to Settlement, Page 2

INSIDE

These cookies are the best in dough

Pracny, eggnog crème brûlée and mandelbread recipes come out on top in the Tribune's Holiday Cookie Contest. **Food & Health**



The Tribune Holiday Cookie Contest winners. **BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE**

